

Letter of Explanation (IRCC)

Andrés Patricio Rivera Benavides
Budapester Straße 24, 01069 Dresden, Germany
Date of birth: 22 July 2002 · Citizenship: Colombia
Passport No.: BF822892

29 September 2026

Immigration, Refugees and Citizenship Canada (IRCC)
Visa Section

Dear Visa Officer,

I am applying for a visitor visa to spend the holiday season in Edmonton, Alberta, with my partner, Maria Beke, a citizen of Canada. I plan to fly from Germany to Edmonton on December 20th 2026 and to leave Canada on January 3rd 2027, flying directly to Bogotá, Colombia, to continue my university studies. My stay in Canada will therefore be about two weeks. This letter explains my current situation, the purpose of the trip, and why I will leave Canada at the end of my visit.

1. Who I am and my current situation

I am a Colombian Civil Engineering student at Universidad Santo Tomás in Bogotá. I started in August 2021 and have completed 140 of the 170 credits in the program (83%) (Document 1). I live with my family in Bogotá.

On July 29th 2025 I came to Germany on a student visa as part of the KOSPIE 2025–2026 academic exchange program, funded by the DAAD (German Academic Exchange Service). The program consisted of one academic semester followed by a professional internship. My internship at EIBS Entwurfs- und Ingenieurbüro Straßenwesen GmbH in Dresden started on June 1st 2026, a little later than originally planned, and the company later extended it until November 30th 2026. The DAAD scholarship ended in July 2026. In my university, this internship is an optional modality that is credited toward the degree as two elective courses of the study plan, once it is completed and approved by the Faculty (Document 2). It is mandatory under the KOSPIE program, but optional in the Colombian curriculum; the two systems work differently. In Document 2, there is a recognition of my student and scholarship status. The document is directed towards the German employment agency but contains all the relevant information, as my university is unable to write a letter for the IRCC for tourism purposes.

I am legally a resident in Germany. My current document (Fiktionsbescheinigung) was issued by the Dresden immigration office on July 21st 2026 because I applied for a new residence permit; it keeps my legal status in force, including my right to continue working in my

internship, while the application is processed, regardless of the office's final decision. It is valid until January 31st 2027, which covers my entire remaining stay in Germany. I have complied with the conditions of my German visa and residence permits throughout my stay. My stay in Germany ends with my internship: after a few days travelling within Germany, I will leave the country permanently.

2. Timeline

Aug 2021 – present

Civil Engineering studies, Universidad Santo Tomás
Bogotá, Colombia

29 Jul 2025 – Jul 2026

KOSPIE academic exchange (DAAD)
Germany

1 Jun – 30 Nov 2026

Professional internship at EIBS GmbH (credited to my degree)
Dresden, Germany

1 – 20 Dec 2026

Last days in Germany before my flight
Germany

20 Dec 2026 – 3 Jan 2027

Visit to my partner
Edmonton, Canada

3 Jan 2027

Return flight Edmonton → Bogotá (I will not return to Germany)
Bogotá, Colombia

Jan 2027

Enrollment for the 2027-1 academic period
Universidad Santo Tomás

1 Feb 2027

Start of classes, 2027-1
Bogotá, Colombia

3. My enrollment status

I want to explain this openly. In the 2026-1 period I enrolled in the two elective courses that were completed through my internship in Germany instead of classroom attendance. As the Dean explains (Document 2), the university credits the internship after it is completed and approved. Since it runs beyond the Colombian semester, these courses appear as pending on my academic record until then. For that reason I did not register for 2026-2 (August–December 2026), as I am still completing the 2026-1 activities abroad, and the university does not allow early registration. I will register for 2027-1 once I am back in Bogotá, before classes begin on February 1st 2027. I remain an active student who has not withdrawn from the program (Document 1).

4. Purpose of the visit and my relationship

María and I have been in a relationship since December 2024. We have had two trips before: in June–July 2025 she visited me in Colombia, where she met my family, and in December 2025 she visited me in Dresden, Germany, and we travelled together to Slovakia to visit her grandparents (Document 3). Because of the distance, this holiday period, right between the end of my internship and the start of my next academic period, is the only time we can spend together for holiday in the coming months. María will host me at her home in Edmonton free of charge; her address and proof of her status are included with her invitation letter.

5. Financial means

I will pay for my entire trip myself. As of September 26th 2026 I have €6,372.74 in my bank account. I receive an internship stipend of €500 per month until October 15th 2026, which increases to €2,500 per month from October 16th to November 30th 2026. In August 2026 I also received a one-time performance bonus of €2,500 from the company. Because my accommodation is provided by my partner, my main expenses will be flights and daily costs, which these funds cover comfortably.

6. Why I will return to Colombia

My degree: I have about two semesters left (remaining courses and my degree project) to graduate as a Civil Engineer. They can only be completed in person at Universidad Santo Tomás in Bogotá, and classes start on February 1st 2027. The internship I am doing now is part of this degree and will only be of value once it is recognized in Colombia.

My family: My family lives in Bogotá, and I live with them.

My visa history: I received a German student visa, respected its conditions, and kept my legal status in Germany at all times. I intend to respect Canadian law in the same way.

7. Enclosed documents

1. Academic Standing Certificate, Universidad Santo Tomás (17 Sep 2026)
(`Academic\_Standing\_Certificate- Firmado.pdf`)

2. Internship Recognition: Dean's letter on the recognition of the internship in Germany (18 Aug 2026) (`Internship\_Recognition.pdf`)
3. Evidence of the relationship: summary, timeline and 6 dated photos of our two meetings (`ProofOfRelationship/Evidence\_of\_Relationship\_Photos.pdf`)

Thank you for considering my application. I am available to provide any additional information you may need.

Sincerely,

Andrés Patricio Rivera Benavides

THE SECRETARY OF THE DIVISION OF ENGINEERING OF THE MAIN CAMPUS OF UNIVERSIDAD SANTO TOMÁS, RECOGNIZED BY DECREES 1772 OF JULY 11, 1966 AND 1583 OF AUGUST 11, 1975,

HEREBY CERTIFIES:

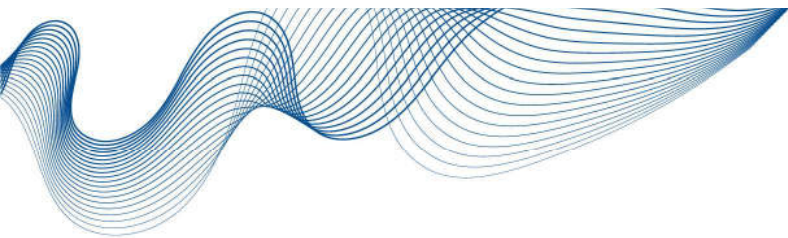
THAT **ANDRÉS PATRICIO RIVERA BENAVIDES**, HOLDER OF COLOMBIAN NATIONAL IDENTITY CARD (CÉDULA DE CIUDADANÍA) No. **1003738235** ISSUED IN BOGOTÁ D.C., WAS ENROLLED IN THE **CIVIL ENGINEERING** PROGRAM, TAKING COURSES OF THE **2026-1** ACADEMIC PERIOD AT THIS UNIVERSITY.

HE BEGAN HIS STUDIES IN THE PROGRAM IN AUGUST 2021. THE PROGRAM CONSISTS OF A TOTAL OF **62** COURSES DISTRIBUTED OVER **10** SEMESTERS, FOR A TOTAL OF **170** CREDITS. TO DATE, HE HAS PASSED **52** COURSES, EQUIVALENT TO **83%** COMPLETION OF HIS STUDY PLAN, WITH 140 CREDITS EARNED.

ISSUED IN BOGOTÁ D.C. ON THE SEVENTEENTH (17TH) DAY OF SEPTEMBER 2026.


LUZ PATRICIA ROCHA CAICEDO
SECRETARY, DIVISION OF ENGINEERING

 **UNIVERSIDAD SANTO TOMÁS**
PRIMER CLAUSTRO UNIVERSITARIO DE COLOMBIA
DIVISIÓN DE INGENIERÍAS
SECRETARÍA DE DIVISIÓN



Bogotá D.C., Colombia, August 18, 2026

Bundesagentur für Arbeit
German Federal Employment Agency

TO WHOM IT MAY CONCERN

Re: Institutional Certification Regarding the Academic Status and Curricular Recognition of the International Professional Internship of Mr. Andrés Patricio Rivera Benavides, Civil Engineering Program (KOSPIE 2025–2026)

I write in my capacity as Dean of the Faculty of Civil Engineering of Universidad Santo Tomás (Bogotá, Colombia), at the request of Mr. Andrés Patricio Rivera Benavides, a student currently enrolled in our Civil Engineering undergraduate program, in connection with additional documentation requested by the German Federal Employment Agency regarding his participation in the KOSPIE 2025–2026 program in Germany. The purpose of this letter is to accurately describe, for the Agency's records, the academic nature of professional internships within our curriculum and the institutional process governing their recognition.

In the interest of full and precise disclosure, the Faculty confirms that professional internships are not, in and of themselves, a mandatory graduation requirement applicable to every student of the Civil Engineering program. Rather, they constitute an optional academic modality that a student may elect during their studies, governed by the Faculty's Internal Regulations on Professional Practices and Internships and by the University's Student Regulations.

When a student chooses to pursue this modality, the internship is not merely an extracurricular activity: it is formally integrated into the student's academic plan of study through a homologation process. Specifically, the internship, once reviewed and approved by the Faculty's Committee on Professional Practices and Internships, is credited as equivalent to two (2) academic elective/emphasis course spaces within the student's curriculum. Because this process entails the execution of an inter-institutional agreement between the University and the host employer, it additionally requires prior review and endorsement by the University's Office of Legal Affairs, which verifies the terms of the agreement before the internship is formally recognized and credited.

Accordingly, and in strict application of the procedure described above, the internship undertaken by Mr. Rivera Benavides in Germany under the KOSPIE 2025–2026 program is, upon compliance with the corresponding institutional requirements, formally recognized within his academic record as credit toward two elective course spaces of the Civil Engineering plan de estudios, and not as a stand-alone or purely voluntary activity outside the curriculum.

Accordingly, and in strict application of the procedure described above, provided that Mr. Rivera Benavides duly completes the corresponding institutional process, including review and approval by the Committee on Professional Practices and Internships and endorsement by the University's Office of Legal Affairs, his internship in Germany under the KOSPIE 2025–2026 program will be formally recognized within his academic record as credit toward two elective course spaces of the Civil Engineering, and not as a stand-alone or purely voluntary activity outside the curriculum.

We trust this clarification provides the Agency with an accurate and transparent account of the academic framework applicable to Mr. Rivera Benavides' internship. The Faculty remains available to provide any additional information or supporting documentation the Agency may require.

Kind regards,



Miguel Mauricio CASTILLA BARBOSA, Dr. Ing
Dean - Faculty of Civil Engineering
Universidad Santo Tomás, Seccional Bogotá D.C.
Bogotá D.C., Colombia

Evidence of Relationship

Applicant: Andrés Patricio Rivera Benavides (Passport BF822892)

Partner: Maria Beke, citizen of Edmonton, Alberta

Maria and I have been in a relationship since December 2024 and will celebrate two years together in December 2026. Our relationship is partially long-distance: Maria lives in Edmonton, Canada, while I lived in Bogotá, Colombia, and since July 2025 in Dresden, Germany. We stay in regular contact through video calls, messages, and visits.

We have been on two trips together:

- June and July 2025: María travelled to Colombia to visit me. We spent time in Bogotá, she met my family, and we travelled together to Anapoima.
- December 2025: María visited me in Dresden, Germany, and we travelled together to Slovakia to visit her grandparents, cousins, aunts and uncles.

The photographs on the following pages were taken during these two visits and are arranged in chronological order.

We have not seen each other since December 2025. The visit I am applying for (December 20th 2026 – January 3rd 2027) will be the first time I visit María in Canada.

Timeline of our in-person meetings

Dates	Place	What we did	Photo
December 2024	n/a	Start of our relationship (long distance)	n/a
June – July 2025	Bogotá and Anapoima, Colombia	María visited me in Colombia and met my family	1 – 4
December 2025	Dresden, Germany and Bratislava, Slovakia	María visited me in Germany; we visited her grandparents in Slovakia together	5 – 6
20 Dec 2026 – 3 Jan 2027	Edmonton, Canada	Planned visit (this application)	n/a

Visit 1 – María in Colombia (June – July 2025)



Photo 1 – Plaza de Bolívar, Bogotá, Colombia · June 2025

María and me in Bogotá's main square, shortly after she arrived in Colombia.



Photo 2 – Bogotá, Colombia · July 2025

María having lunch with me and my family in Bogotá.



Photo 3 – Anapoima, Cundinamarca, Colombia · July 2025
A trip together to Anapoima, near Bogotá.



Photo 4 – Amusement park, Bogotá, Colombia · July 2025
A day together at an amusement park in Bogotá.

Visit 2 – María in Germany and Slovakia (December 2025)



Photo 5 – Dresden, Germany · December 2025

María visiting me in Dresden, in front of the Frauenkirche and the Christmas market.



Photo 6 – Slovakia · December 2025

María and me with her grandparents in Slovakia, where we travelled together from Germany.